

GREAT SANDY-TANAMI DESERT

Australia's vast northwestern deserts are rich in wildlife

The Great Sandy and Tanami deserts sport a range of semiarid to arid habitats, from shifting dunes of loose sand to windswept bare rock to low rolling plains dominated by shrubby hummocks of Australia's endemic dryland grass known as spinifex. In various forms, spinifex covers almost one-fifth of the entire continent. In the far southeast of the ecoregion squats the glowing sandstone mound of Uluru, formerly known as Ayers Rock.

Grass-based food chain

Spinifex's sharp, silica-rich, abrasive leaves deter many large grazing animals, yet the soft new shoots and plentiful seeds produced after rain feed a myriad of small creatures. These range from ants, termites, beetles, and cicadas to small parrots such as the budgerigar, or parakeet, as well as the painted firetail and the omnivorous dusky grass wren. Tiny native mice, including

the spinifex hopping mouse and sandy inland mouse, also depend on it. Grass-dwelling insects feed reptiles such as thorny devils and knob-tailed geckoes, and also the smallest marsupial: the shrewlike long-tailed planigale. Farther up the food chains are larger hunters such as the desert death adder, gray falcon, and Australia's largest bird of prey, the wedge-tailed eagle.

This web of life is diverse but sporadic, thriving after downpours, then struggling to survive for months, even years, if the summer rains fail. In recent decades the desert ecology has been unbalanced by introduced grazing animals that can survive on spinifex, especially feral donkeys and camels.



ELUSIVE HUNTER
The gray falcon is a keen hunter of small birds and some small mammals. Because it has a large range and is difficult to identify in the wild, estimated numbers are problematic. Due to habitat loss, however, they are thought to be declining.

GRAY FALCON

NOMADIC FLOCKS

More familiar as a caged bird, the budgerigar is a native of Australian deserts. Large, colorful, chattering flocks fly between seed-rich areas and oases in the wild, and livestock water supplies have helped to extend their range.

BUDGERIGARS

DESERTED WALLABIES
The black-footed rock wallaby feeds during darker, cooler, and damper hours and gains what water it needs from food. Increasing numbers of introduced grazing animals have fragmented its dwindling populations.

BLACK-FOOTED ROCK WALLABY

One of Australia's least populated areas

Has dune ridges up to 30 miles (50 km) long